

Read the Word and Break a Stronghold

Before I even begin to pass in review, I want to mention the last few services. The Holy Spirit has had me on the border of intercession. At times in public I am almost afraid to yield to the grieving I feel deep inside my soul over some of the things going on in the body of Christ right now, especially in the realms of immorality and sin.

As far as witchcraft is concerned in America, I know witches have been fasting and praying, or chanting, to their prince of darkness, Satan, for the destruction of the morals of Christian families, Christian ethics, and especially divorce. They are praying for the breakup of Christian homes, and especially the clergy and those in ministry.

For the sake of revival and for understanding our enemy, being wise as serpents and harmless as doves, the Holy Ghost has thrown us into this portion of prayer. We have been studying prayer, but He has thrown us into this kind of praying.

I have been grieved because I am running into this more and more. I cannot teach on Satan's war machine, how Satan comes in and takes preachers apart, especially if they are getting thousands born again into the kingdom, without afterward having preachers come up for counseling.

When I break down the process by which a preacher or believer is rendered bound in a stronghold of sin, they come and say, "Brother Roberson, I do not know what to say. My wife does not know. My good friends do not know. Nobody knows. It seems like I pray and repent, but I am out of control. I do not know what to do. Can you help me?"

Some of these preachers are so shipwrecked, and their emotions are so gone, that they carry on a form of godliness. They perform their ministerial duties and do what they need to do, but they are so ashamed they cannot tell their wife or the people closest to them because those people hold them in such high regard.

You do not know how much of this I am running into.

When Ed Cole preached at a Kenneth Copeland meeting on lasciviousness of the flesh, what King James calls "superfluity of naughtiness," probably between one-third and one-fourth of the preachers came forward who were guilty of personal filthiness of the flesh: habitual things involving pornography available in motel rooms and literature, and the abuse of their own bodies.

Does it do any good, when Satan brings a wave like that on the body of Christ, to sit around and criticize and scream at everybody because they are operating in sin? When a person falls to that kind of sin, he is the victim of a well-planned, strategic, organized machine. When Satan finally finishes and takes him out, locking him in that kind of stronghold, it is only the last step of something very well organized.

This is why Jesus said to be wise as serpents and harmless as doves. He expects you and me to know our enemy.

It does no good to scream at a man, point a finger, and say, "We have to cut this sin out of the body." You can line them all up in counseling and ask if they think they should be doing it, and they will tell you no. Everybody knows that kind of sin is wrong.

When I was in ultra-holiness, they screamed at us about sin all the time, but nobody stepped forward and told us what to do about it. We got condemned all the time. Most of the time the preachers were yelling about what they themselves were consciously condemned about the most.

It does no good to yell and yell at people unless you step forward and help them understand first what got them into the mess. If you can understand what got a person in, then you can better understand what will get him out. If you understand the process that caused a person to fall, you can reverse that process.

Have you noticed how things come in waves? It seems like all the preachers are falling to adultery at once, all are stealing money at once, all are caught up in scandals, suing each other, and fighting to fire each other at once. No sooner does one wave subside than the devil is building momentum for another one, preying on the weaknesses of another group of human beings.

I used to wonder why these things came in waves, why everybody seemed to fall to the same thing at the same time. I do not wonder anymore. Since the Lord showed me Satan's war machine, that kind of thing opened up.

If Paul had outlined Satan's operation the same way he outlined the body of Christ, he might have said that Satan gave first principalities, second powers, third rulers of the darkness of this world, and fourth spiritual wickedness in high places.

It probably happened a generation or so ago when Satan realized the value of media: television, music, entertainment, newspapers, and the printed page. When he saw where our civilization was going, he pulled his principalities into counsel and said, "I want you to destroy the morals of the body of Christ. I want divorce to rise in Christianity like never before. I want immorality. I want doctrinal preaching that loosens the hold on holiness. I want a perversion of grace preached that says all this is covered and acceptable because God is a God of grace."

He holds principalities accountable for the destruction of morals in the body of Christ.

Principalities are an angelic class. Beneath them are powers, a middle class of wicked spirits who supply power for lying signs and wonders. Beneath powers are rulers of the darkness of this world, sentry spirits that guard over darkness. When revival comes, their job is to organize resistance against the invasion of light. If necessary, they will shift seven spirits more wicked than the one that came out of a person in order to destroy whatever invasion of revival is happening.

Beneath them are multitudes of unclean spirits, what Jesus classified as devils or unclean spirits. They are called spiritual wickedness in high places because "high places" refers to the air below mountaintop level, the realm where they get involved with human beings directly to depress and harass.

When Satan gives orders to a principality, that principality gives orders to powers, powers administrate it through regions, rulers of darkness hand it down, and multitudes of unclean spirits begin working directly on human beings. Their job is to break down morals through uncaptured thoughts that become high things exalting themselves against the knowledge of God, then imaginations with no foundation of truth, runaway imaginations empowered by lust and emotion until a person swears he cannot quit.

That is how waves are created.

Satan realized the power of media, television, newspapers, the printed page, and especially music. Music seems to bypass a person's will and open emotions to all kinds of spirits. Along with drugs, it has been one of the most powerful evangelistic tools the enemy has used on our younger generation.

When these unclean spirits go to work all at once, they begin to create a wave. When that wave of immorality reaches fullness, everybody seems to be falling at once to the same set of tricks. Preachers divorce their wives. Churches are shaken. It seems to happen everywhere because people have been victimized by a well-schemed, militaristic ploy of the devil executed with precision.

The devil knew that when he unleashed these unclean spirits on the body of Christ to indoctrinate and break people down, one of the most effective things he could do was loose powers on people in key positions: media, entertainment, education, and culture.

When we think of demon possession, we often think only of a perverted criminal, some slobbering person growling on the floor, someone so obviously wrong that even a child can tell something is wrong. That is the devil, but it is only one part of his operation.

When powers get behind personalities, people can be as possessed as possessed can be and still be geniuses in their own right. The devil uses them in key positions to influence entertainment and media. Someone under demonic influence may be deciding what programs come into your home through television.

The devil knows he is not likely to make you let your guard down in church. He does it when you are sitting in front of a television, alone, until he can push your ethics into the background and you will watch more and more of what you used to refuse.

God has always looked at media and television as tools for His purposes, but Christians have been slow, and the devil has jumped the gun on them.

Through uncaptured thoughts, through sight, hearing, and music, Satan works while you sit there hour after hour. Those uncaptured thoughts become temptations. Temptation becomes enticement. Enticement draws a man away. Lust conceives. Sin forms a stronghold and brings death.

Do not let a demon-possessed personality with swelling words and overblown confidence fool with your morality. Wrong is wrong.

How are you arrested and taken backward? Not all at once. You are too smart for that. It happens one degenerated step at a time as uncaptured thoughts take hold and become high things, replacing what used to control your life. Those high things exalt themselves against the knowledge of God with the intention of replacing His knowledge with themselves. Finally they become imaginations, out-of-control thought systems empowered by emotion with no scriptural foundation of truth.

If we can understand what gets a man into that mess, then glory be to God, we can understand what gets him out.

I do not think there is a preacher alive worth his salt who has not had the devil come to him and attempt to break him down in those realms. I do not think there is a believer worth stopping whom the devil does not attempt to break down one way or another.

I have been grieved because this wave is reaching fullness. David Wilkerson prophesied years ago that there would be a day when clergy could get this kind of material in their rooms at night. Now, with satellites and commercial television, what he prophesied has come to pass. God was warning of the danger even then.

In the destruction of reasonings, when a man has been placed into a stronghold, Paul says:

The weapons of our warfare are not carnal, but mighty through God to the pulling down of strong holds.

They cannot even be approached in the carnal realm. But we do have weaponry from God that will pull these prisons down. Paul tells you what the prisons are: imaginations, high things exalted against the knowledge of God, and uncaptured thoughts.

Why call it a stronghold? Why call it a prison? A prison is designed for incarceration. It holds a man against his will.

I have preachers come for counseling who are carrying on forms of godliness. They are preaching, performing their duties, and doing what they are supposed to do, yet they are locked in a prison and do not know how to get out.

They say, "I know it is wrong, but to tell the truth, I want to keep doing it. Something inside me wants to be free, but if you ask my emotions, I like it. I do not want to stop."

That is the destruction of reasonings and emotionalism.

I ask, "Would you consider praying in the Holy Ghost a couple of hours a day?"

"No. My emotions do not want to be free enough to do that."

"Would you worship God for an hour or two?"

"No. Why would I want to worship God when I want to sin? I am only here because something deep inside wants to be free. Emotionally, I do not."

"Will you confess the Word? Will you walk the floor and minister to yourself in psalms, hymns, and spiritual songs?"

"No. Emotionally, I do not feel like it."

They want someone else to pray until they want to get set free. We can pray. We can bind the devil, break his power, and cast him off their lives. But because of emotional addiction, it is usually not long before they are back in again, because I cannot continue to be their willpower.

That is what a prison is.

To my surprise, after Augie preached faithfully and I listened to his testimony, I heard how the strong man came and tried to take him apart emotionally, thread by thread, unweaving his garment of righteousness and salvation until it emotionally broke him down. It broke Lee down too. His wife bordered on insanity and had a nervous breakdown. It was not just circumstantial; things could be going well, and it would still hit.

Augie said, "I knew uncompromisingly that I was fighting for my life."

He had to get the Word of God out. At the time he was in India most of the time with his father, who ran a Christian school with thousands of children in it. Augie was administrator of the school, so he did have time that he could lock himself away.

If my salvation is at stake, I will make the time. If my emotions are so wrong that I do not want help, then the first thing I will do is anything that will turn my emotions, even if I do not want them turned. If I know from the spiritual realm that it will save me from hell, I will begin to do it.

Augie knew he was fighting for his life. Six hours a day he read the Word of God from cover to cover every two weeks. Genesis to Revelation, every two weeks, for a year.

I asked him to show me how he did it. He went to his couch, opened his Bible on it, laid himself over it, and read. He just read for six solid hours. He would not let himself stop.

I can tell you what that did. After I kept hearing Augie teach that, the Holy Ghost prompted me to start counseling people to do the same. In my mind I wondered, "What will that do? They will not do that either." But to my surprise, most of them were willing to carry the Bible, sit down, and read for a while.

So I got bold in counseling. I said, "Even if you crawl out from under a slimy rock of the lust of the flesh, ask Jesus to forgive you by faith, then get your Word out. Read an hour in the Old Testament and an hour in the New. The next day, go back and do it again. No matter what you feel like, do it."

It works for sin. It will also work for poverty and other areas where your mind is messed up.

When a person begins reading like that, he has reversed the whole process that brought him to where he was: an out-of-control emotional mess full of lust. It all started with uncaptured thoughts as a Christian. The same process that brings a sinner out through the transformation and renewing of the mind will bring a re-indoctrinated Christian back out again.

James says:

Every man is tempted, when he is drawn away of his own lust, and enticed.

Then when lust hath conceived, it bringeth forth sin: and sin, when it is finished, bringeth forth death.

First come uncaptured thoughts, temptations thrown at you by hordes of devils through media, publications, educational systems, and demon-influenced personalities who patiently feed you one small portion at a time until you are destroyed.

If it all started with uncaptured thoughts flowing through me and increasing day by day, then it stands to reason that reading the Word of God for two hours a day begins to run God's thoughts through my mind, soul, and spirit. The more I read, the more God's thoughts run through me and begin replacing the uncaptured thoughts.

When I do not feel like praying, worshiping, reading, or confessing the Word, what do I feel like? Maybe I can still read. Even when my emotions are wrecked and I cannot dig up the want-to, emotions are the fruit of uncaptured thoughts.

When God's thoughts flow through you hour after hour, even involuntarily on your part, those thoughts begin to gender a little emotion. You begin to drift into His thoughts. Like a fisherman snagging a fish and reeling it in, those thoughts hook an emotion here and pull it into your soul. Then they hook another one there. Soon there are enough emotions to begin opposing the wrong ones.

If you keep going, you will get your emotions back to pray in tongues. You will start saying, "I feel like worshiping God now." You will start worshiping God because, even against your emotions, if you will read the Word, you will begin recapturing the emotions you lost. You will start feeling like serving God again.

James 1 says:

Let no man say when he is tempted, I am tempted of God: for God cannot be tempted with evil.

In order to tempt you with evil, God would have to be tempted with evil. He says not to say that when you are tempted, you are tempted by God.

Every man is tempted, when he is drawn away of his own lust, and enticed.

Then when lust hath conceived, it bringeth forth sin: and sin, when it is finished, bringeth forth death.

Do not err, my beloved brethren.

Every good gift and every perfect gift is from above, and cometh down from the Father of lights, with whom is no variableness, neither shadow of turning.

Then he gives you the progression to a stronghold and says:

Wherefore lay apart all filthiness and superfluity of naughtiness...

Filthiness speaks of filthiness of the flesh. "Superfluity of naughtiness" means beyond acceptable limits. It is not yet full lasciviousness or adultery, but it is the temptation stage beyond acceptable limits: "You should not be watching that. You should not be looking at that. You should not be reading that. Being married, you should not be acting that way toward that woman or that man."

He says to lay it all aside because that kind of temptation results in enticement. Being drawn away by your own lust, lust will conceive. It will become part of your soul and life, begin its control process, and when fullness comes it will bring forth sin, and sin brings death.

So he told you to put it away. Do not even get started in it.

Then he says:

Receive with meekness the engrafted word, which is able to save your souls.

Receive it with meekness, with a teachable spirit. Engraft it as a living branch. Instead of yielding to the other process, lend yourself to the flow of God's thoughts through you hour after hour. Instead of superfluity of naughtiness and uncaptured thoughts tempting the lusts of the flesh, give yourself to the engrafted Word of God, which is able to stabilize your soul in Jesus Christ.

He that knows these things will never fall.

Go to James 3 for a moment.

My brethren, be not many masters, knowing that we shall receive the greater condemnation.

If I am not to be many masters, a jack of all trades and master of none, then what should I master? He tells you in the next verse:

For in many things we offend all. If any man offend not in word, the same is a perfect man, and able also to bridle the whole body.

You mean my body cannot control me? Not as long as uncaptured thoughts and lusts cannot control what I am saying and doing.

That is why Jesus said, "Take no thought, saying, What shall we eat? What shall we drink? Wherewithal shall we be clothed?"

James says this man is able to bridle his whole body. You put bits in horses' mouths so a smaller man can sit on a large horse and make it go where he wants. A small helm turns a massive ship. James likens the control of a horse and the control of a ship to the control of your body through your tongue and what you are saying.

So I am not going to master everybody else's business. I am going to tame my tongue. If I can tame my tongue, I can tame my thoughts. If I can tame my thoughts, I can bridle my body. If I can bridle my body, glory be to God, I can walk in the fullness of the engrafted Word of God in my soul.

Stand to your feet, and let us worship God.